

Harry Potter & Edinburgh - Kids

UK Family Tour

The Wizard City

Here is a thought to carry around Edinburgh today. When you rode the train into this city, you did almost exactly what a woman named Joanne Rowling did in December of nineteen ninety-three. She stepped off a train with a baby daughter, very little money, and a suitcase holding something secret. Inside were three chapters about a boy wizard called Harry Potter.

Nobody knew her name back then. She came here because her sister lived in Edinburgh, and she needed somewhere to start over. She pushed her daughter's pram through these streets, and when the baby fell asleep, she ducked into cafes, ordered one coffee, and wrote as fast as she could before the baby woke up. Page by page, in this city, the story you know grew into a book. And fourteen years later, in a fancy hotel room about ten minutes' walk from the castle, she wrote the very last sentence of the very last book. Harry Potter begins and ends in Edinburgh.

And honestly, doesn't this city look the part? A castle sitting on top of a black volcanic rock. Crooked alleyways that dive between buildings like secret passages. A spooky old graveyard where, if you hunt carefully, you can find the name of Lord Voldemort himself carved into a real gravestone.

So here's your mission today. In the stories coming up, you'll visit the cafes where the books got written, and find out which one is fibbing about it. You'll go grave-hunting for Voldemort. You'll walk a curvy rainbow-colored street that people swear is the real Diagon Alley, and hear what the author says about that. You'll peek at the hotel room where the story ended. And you'll find out why Hogwarts itself, according to the books, is hiding somewhere in Scotland right now. Maybe even somewhere you're going this week. Wands ready? Off we go.

The Cafe Where the Magic Got Written

Picture this. A young mum in a chilly Edinburgh winter, pushing a pram around the streets until her baby finally nods off. The moment those little eyes close, she hurries into a cafe, finds a corner table, orders a single coffee, and starts scribbling like mad. She has maybe an hour before the baby wakes. Every sleeping minute counts, because in her notebook, Harry Potter is learning to fly.

The cafe she went to most was called Nicolson's, up a flight of stairs on a busy corner not far from here. She picked it for a sneaky reason. It was partly owned by her brother-in-law, so nobody hassled her for sitting there for hours over one cold cup of coffee. Big chunks of the very first Harry Potter book were written at those tables. The cafe is gone now, it's been other restaurants since, but there's a plaque on the corner of the building telling you what happened upstairs.

Now for a little detective work. A few streets away sits another cafe, The Elephant House, and for years it had a big sign in the window saying Birthplace of Harry Potter. Sounds impressive. But is it true? Time to look at the evidence. The idea for Harry Potter popped into the author's head in nineteen ninety, on a delayed train in England, years before she ever came to Edinburgh. The first chapters were written in London. And Rowling herself finally said it straight out on the internet, she'd been writing Harry Potter

for several years before she ever set foot in that cafe. So it can't be the birthplace. But, she added, she really did write there, so we'll let them off. Case closed. Not the birthplace. Still a real Harry Potter cafe.

Then the poor Elephant House had its own disaster. In August of twenty twenty-one a fire tore through the building, and the cafe had to close for more than four years. But firefighters and builders saved something special, the actual table where Rowling used to sit and write. It was fixed up, and when the cafe finally reopened just after Christmas in twenty twenty-five, the table went back in. Today her portrait hangs in that room next to other Edinburgh writers.

The bit I love most is this. Rowling was broke while she wrote that first book. She was living on money the government gives people who have almost nothing. Twelve publishers said no thanks to Harry Potter before one small one finally said yes. Think about that next time you're in a cafe. The person at the corner table, nursing one cold coffee and scribbling in a notebook, might be writing the most famous story of the next hundred years. And nobody around them has any idea.

Grave-Hunting for Voldemort

Ready for the creepiest treasure hunt in Edinburgh? Behind a church called Greyfriars Kirk there's an old, old graveyard, full of mossy stones and leaning tombs, some of them hundreds of years old. And somewhere in there, waiting for you to find it, is the grave of Lord Voldemort.

Well, sort of. Head toward the back of the graveyard and hunt for a tall stone against the wall with the name Thomas Riddell on it. Riddell with two Ls, so almost Tom Riddle, the boy who grew up to become You Know Who. The real Thomas Riddell was no dark wizard. He was a gentleman who died in eighteen oh six, aged seventy-two. The same stone remembers his son, another Thomas Riddell, a young army captain who died far away on the island of Trinidad when he was only twenty-six. Fans from all over the world come to find this stone, and you'll often see a little path worn in the grass leading right to it.

And the hunt isn't over. This graveyard also holds William McGonagall, who is famous for being possibly the worst poet who ever lived. His poems were so bad that crowds laughed and threw things at him while he read. Sound familiar? Professor McGonagall, the strictest, cleverest teacher at Hogwarts, shares his name, and Rowling once wrote that it tickled her to borrow the name of such a terrible poet for such a brilliant witch. There's even a stone for an Elizabeth Moodie, and fans like to whisper about Mad-Eye Moody when they find it.

But now, the twist. Did Rowling actually creep around this graveyard collecting names? She says no. A few years ago she explained online that one of her own kids went on a Harry Potter walking tour of Edinburgh, just for a laugh, and came home full of amazing facts that were completely new to her. Imagine that. Your own mum wrote the books, and the tour guide knows secrets about them that she doesn't. She did once say that she collected unusual names from all sorts of places, including gravestones. So maybe a name like Riddell floated into her head somewhere and stuck. Or maybe it's all coincidence. Nobody knows for sure, not even her, and that's the honest truth.

One more thing before you leave. Look over the graveyard wall and you'll see a grand grey building with pointy towers, like a small castle. That's George Heriot's School, built in the sixteen hundreds with money left by the king's own jeweller, so that orphan boys could go to school for free. Its students are sorted into four houses. Four houses, a castle school, right next to Voldemort's grave. People love to say it's the real Hogwarts. Rowling has never said so. But go on, look at it and tell me you can't picture the sorting hat in there.

The Real Diagon Alley?

Stand at the top of Victoria Street and look down. The street curves away below you like a slide, and every shopfront is painted a different color. Red, blue, yellow, green, all leaning together down the slope. There's even a walkway running along the rooftops on one side, so the street has two levels, like shops stacked on shops. Half the people around you are probably taking photos, and lots of them are thinking exactly the same thing. Diagon Alley.

Play the game yourself. Can you spot a shop that could sell wands? At number forty there really is a wizard shop, stuffed with scarves and robes and chocolate frogs, usually with a queue of fans outside. For years, people say, there was a joke shop near the bottom of the street, and fans loved the idea that it was the model for the Weasley twins' shop. A curved, colorful, magical-looking street with a joke shop on it. It has to be Diagon Alley, right?

Time for the truth, and it's a shocker. A few years ago Rowling answered this question herself, straight out. No real street inspired Diagon Alley. It came out of her head. She said she'd never even seen Victoria Street when she invented Diagon Alley, and that she's never visited most of the places around the world that claim to be the inspiration. Fans were flabbergasted. Some argued with her. But she wrote the books, so she gets the final word.

Then why does everyone keep saying it? Because people love a treasure map. When a story is that famous, everybody wants the magic to be real, and findable, and photographable. So cities grow legends around beloved books the way trees grow moss. Shops put up signs, tour guides point, and the story gets bigger every year. It's not lying exactly. It's more like wishing out loud.

And here's a secret that makes Victoria Street better than any legend. It once had a real wizard. Long ago, this slope was a steep zigzag lane called the West Bow, and in the sixteen hundreds a man named Major Weir lived here. He seemed to be the holiest man in Edinburgh, until one day he confessed to being a wizard, and in sixteen seventy the city executed him for witchcraft. For many years afterward, people were too scared to live in his house, swearing they saw strange lights and heard his ghost. So forget Diagon Alley for a second. This street had its own wizard story three hundred years before Harry Potter was born. Look down the curve one more time. Real magic rumors, painted shops, and a mystery. Not bad for one little street.

The Hotel Room Where the Story Ended

Every story has to end somewhere. Harry Potter's ending has an exact address, and you can walk right past it. Find the grand hotel with the huge clock tower at the east end of Princes Street, next to the train station. That's the Balmoral. Count up to the fifth floor. Behind one of those windows, the last Harry Potter book was finished.

Here's how it happened. By two thousand and seven, Rowling wasn't a broke young mum in a cafe anymore. She was one of the most famous writers on Earth, and she was fighting to finish the seventh and final book, Harry Potter and the Deathly Hallows. Millions of readers were waiting. And at home, there was always noise, always something. So she packed up her work and checked into room five five two at the Balmoral, just to get some peace and finish the thing.

The room won. On the eleventh of January, two thousand and seven, in that room, she wrote the final words of the final chapter of the final book. Seventeen years after Harry first appeared in her head on a delayed train, the story was done.

And then she did something you are absolutely not supposed to do in a hotel. In the room stood a marble bust, a statue of the Greek god Hermes. Rowling picked up a pen and wrote right on it. She wrote that J K Rowling finished writing Harry Potter and the Deathly Hallows in this room, five five two, on the

eleventh of January, two thousand and seven. She signed the statue like it was a giant autograph book. If you drew on the furniture in a fancy hotel, you'd be in enormous trouble. When the most famous author in the world does it, the hotel throws a party.

And the Balmoral did something wonderful next. Instead of scrubbing the statue clean, they put it under a glass dome to protect it, and turned the whole room into the J K Rowling Suite. The door was painted purple, and it got a brass door knocker shaped like an owl, like a certain snowy owl you might know. Best of all, the number on the door isn't five five two anymore. It's five five two and three quarters. If you know how to get to Platform Nine and Three Quarters, you know exactly why.

People now pay well over a thousand pounds a night to sleep in the room where Harry Potter ended. Or you can do what we're doing, stand outside for free, look up at the fifth floor, and imagine the exact moment a pen stopped moving and the biggest story of our time was finally complete.

Hogwarts Is in Scotland

Where is Hogwarts, really? Not the film set, not a theme park. In the books, where is the castle supposed to be? The answer is all around you. Hogwarts is in Scotland.

Think about how students get there. They board the Hogwarts Express at King's Cross station in London, you may have stood in that exact station, and the train chugs north all day, arriving after dark. Rowling explained it once in an interview. Travel a whole day north from King's Cross and where do you end up? Scotland. She said that even before she lived here, she always imagined Hogwarts in Scotland, a huge castle by a lake, tucked in the Highlands where the maps run out of towns and fill up with mountains.

The filmmakers agreed. When they needed the Hogwarts Express for the movies, they used a real steam train called the Jacobite, which still runs today across the west of Scotland, on one of the most beautiful railway lines in the world. In the films, you see it thunder across a giant curved bridge with twenty-one stone arches, high above a green valley. That bridge is real. It's the Glenfinnan Viaduct, and the flying car scene in Chamber of Secrets happens right above it. Every day in summer, crowds hike up the hillside just to watch the steam train curl across those arches, whistle echoing, exactly like the start of a new school year. The lakes in the films are real too. Deep, dark Highland lochs played the Great Lake below Hogwarts, and a tiny island on one of them became Dumbledore's white tomb.

Now here's where you come in. You're spending days in Scotland on this trip, and that means you can hunt for your own Hogwarts. Tomorrow-ish you'll ride a boat to Inchcolm, a little island with a ruined abbey sitting alone in the sea. Grey stone towers, screaming seabirds, water on every side. Doesn't that sound like something out of the wizarding world? At Stirling you'll walk through a real castle where real kings and queens lived, with great halls big enough for a Yule Ball. And when you climb Arthur's Seat, the old volcano above Edinburgh, look north across the water toward the mountains. Somewhere out there, says the story, hidden from Muggle eyes, is a castle no map will ever show you.

Remember, Muggles can't see Hogwarts. To them it looks like a mouldering old ruin with a sign saying keep out, danger. So every ruined castle you pass in Scotland, and you'll pass plenty, might secretly be it. Keep score out the window. That's not a broken tower, that's just what they want you to see. By the end of this trip you'll have spotted a dozen possible Hogwartises. One of them, who knows, might be the real thing.